

MARK LIVSHITZ/FIDE



"This young chess generation blends discipline with creativity. They are a perfect balance of talent and character"

–NITIN NARANG, President, All India Chess Federation

Audiences cheered the breakthrough moves, broke into Gukesh chants and there was even a live rendition of a song dedicated to him, "Go Go Guki Go". Online viewership was impressive too. The average reach of each game was 1.5 million views with the highest coming for the final game, 3.9 million views. Another promising stat—as much as 70 per cent of the online audience was from the 19-34 age group. While Tamil Nadu continues to be the mecca of chess in India, the most views for the livestream came from Maharashtra, Uttar Pradesh and Karnataka.

If the run of the past two years is anything to go by, India's chess future looks extremely promising. For professional players, it's an expensive pursuit, finding funding for the training and the travel to tournaments abroad. Luckily, apart from public sector companies, more private companies are now betting big money to support India's bright stars. Gukesh and Vaishali have WestBridge, Quantbox and Adani back Arjun and Pragg respectively, and Nihal Sarin's got Akshayakalpa. The All India Chess Federation also plays its part; a portion of its Rs 65 crore annual budget is used in contracts for 42 top players in seven different age categories (up to 19 years) as well as free coaching to 320 other selected players. Federation president Nitin Narang says, "Often, players drop their passion owing to financial constraints, but with financial support and other facilities, they will be better positioned to excel."

The question now is, can they shun the noise and stay focused on the game, more so in this age of social media where scrutiny is relentless. "I have told them how I do and did things," says Anand. "They have to take that and adapt it to a new time. Many of them have impressed me with how quickly they have grown into their own."

It helps that chess's Gen Z generation of Grandmasters are committed and value their role as the game's ambassadors. "Gukesh will be the next Virat Kohli of India," proclaims Sagar Shah, who has been tracking his evolution since 2016. "When he says, 'I don't want to cheat at anything in life,' it's just the person he is. All of them are hardworking, honest and prioritise the processes over result. For youngsters, they are great role models."

For the world champion, reaching the summit of chess is only the beginning of his journey in chess. Gukesh brings a Rajini-like swagger to what is perceived as a serious sport just in the manner he strides his way to the chessboard or adjusts his shirt collar during the game. A fan of biographies of sporting greats, he understands the significance of a healthy mind which is why he engaged mental conditioning coach Paddy Upton—of Indian cricket team fame—in his team. There's also a self-awareness, which is why even after becoming world champion he declares he isn't the best and has much to do to catch up with the mighty Magnus Carlsen. If the games at the world championships were anything to go by, Gukesh is an audacious challenger, who refuses to give in. Persistent, he sits with eyes closed calculating moves that seem to bamboozle opponents. Ding certainly seemed frazzled. "I just like to play chess, yeah," Gukesh said at a press conference after one of the games. In the simplicity of that statement is hidden a grand ambition, a player who wants to be a GOAT (greatest of all time).

The real rewards of Gukesh's achievement and those of others of his generation will perhaps be felt in the decades to come. For now, at the end of a tumultuous year, India's young grandmasters spearheaded by Gukesh have done enough to lift our collective pride and justify why the INDIA TODAY editors declared them the 2024 Newsmaker of the Year. Here's hoping India's chess tribe rules the squares for many more years ahead. ■